Client: InsuranceAsia News | May 3, 2021

INSURANCE ASIA NEWS

Hyperconnecting reinsurance

Supercede co-founders Ben Rose and Jerad Leigh talk about giving the industry superpowers.

With a second lockdown renewal successfully completed in Japan on April 1, reinsurers and brokers have been patting themselves on the back for a job well done. And deservedly so.

But the industry is still a long way from being truly digital. Preparing, validating and compiling all the data to complete a reinsurance deal remains a time-consuming and tedious process, while sourcing risk or capacity is more challenging than ever.

"The way that deals are done hasn't fundamentally changed," says Ben Rose, co-founder and president of Supercede, a dedicated reinsurance technology company. "Everyone is very pleased with themselves because trading is happening, but it's still basically all being done through emails, zip files and spreadsheets. Replacing meetings with video calls does not make it much more efficient."

Rose and his co-founder Jerad Leigh spoke to InsuranceAsia News about their mission to modernise trading in the reinsurance industry through the creation of a "hyperconnected" reinsurance trading platform that truly harnesses technology to match risk with capital.

Supercede combines an established e-placement platform and reinsurance network with tools for data preparation. The goal is to make life easier for all existing market participants — cedants, brokers and reinsurers — rather than to disintermediate the broking function.

"We're broker-centric," says Leigh. "We've spent a lot of time talking to cedants and they actually value their brokers and the role that they play."

However, nobody values digging through vast spreadsheets in search of data for rekeying elsewhere. Streamlining these kinds of chores can dramatically reduce the amount of time it takes to close deals and empowers everyone involved to have much more productive interactions.

"Too often, brokers spend more time compiling data instead of doing deals," says Leigh, who is also the company's chief executive and was previously part of Aon Benfield's Japan team. "For example, the lead time for the April 1 renewal in Japan can start in September."

Leveraging technology to help cedants and brokers prepare submission packs and ensure that data flows smoothly is an obvious opportunity for efficiency gains.

Post-pandemic

An online network that brings together reinsurers, brokers and cedants is another important part of Supercede's platform that has only grown in importance during the pandemic.

While many in the London market continue to emphasise the importance of face-to-face relationships, even after Covid-19, the Supercede duo argue that there is too much serendipity involved in the status quo.

Any client won through a chance encounter at a conference is also a deal that may just as easily never have happened. This is particularly true in Asia, where drumming up business in person is an obvious impediment to connecting risk with capacity that may be available in other regions.

Unlike other placement networks, Supercede is independent from existing industry incumbents and adopts a traditional approach to quoting, authorising and signing, which means that it can handle complex, bespoke deals.

Formerly known as Riskbook, Supercede rebranded after taking on £2 million of funding in 2020 and building out its offering to include the new analytics solution.

Last week it joined Lloyd's Lab, the market's insurtech programme, which will provide a forum for feedback across all the syndicates and help to develop the platform for even the most niche lines of business.

"In the long term, I hope that if we lay the groundwork well enough we will actually see reinsurance made easier to buy — and therefore we'll see more reinsurance bought," says Rose. "So who knows, we might even be able to help grow the industry."

That is a goal everyone can get behind.